

As Jackal sat there, his mind was racing. He was screaming on the inside, Will I make it? I just want to be happy. But what about Mom? She never likes my dreams or ideas. Follow your heart. But I love her, and I might lose everything if I don't help her and do what she wants best for me... fuck. Suddenly, he snapped back to reality.

His attention was caught by a glowing fish swimming through the river in front of him. His feet felt cool as they sat in the chilled water. He had heard about the recent phenomenon of glowing fish in the area but didn't know much about them, only that they were thought to be caused by an outlet. "I wish I could go back to before they arrived," he thought. He lay down flat on the grass, feet still in the water, and yawned. He looked up at the clouds and began to doze off.

When he woke up, he was in a dark cold room with a rotting scent and there were nine hooded figures in front of him. Their robes were white with weird colorful shapes on them. Above them was a glowing fish, which appeared to be swimming in the air. He tried to stand up, but was strapped to the chair he was sitting on. He began to squirm and try to wiggle free, but as he did so, the hooded figures moved in.

As they got closer, he could see their mutilated faces. They were black and rotted, some of them had spots where you could see the bone from where maggots were eating out of them. Their facial expressions looked immensely painful. "Welcome back, number 10," they said in perfect unison. Jackal quickly looked down at his hands as a sharp pain pierced his fingertips. From the tips, they were turning black. They looked dead, as if his body was dying.

The hooded figures surrounded him, and they all placed one hand in varying places: two on his hands, two on his elbow joints, two on his shoulders, and one on his head. He screamed out in pain, as a burning sensation lit up his entire body. "Fuck," he yelled out, as it was the only word that would come out. He found it harder and harder to breathe as the pain intensified. On the right side of his hip, a circle of pain was forming. He tried to scream, but only air came out. Tears rolled down his cheeks, and he was horrified. He kicked his legs and tried everything he could think of to escape. Once the circle of pain had reached its height, he felt his consciousness leaving, but it suddenly all stopped. And his feet felt cool.

He sat up and realized it was just a dream. "What the hell." Jackal looked around and saw someone laying on the ground right next to him, feet also in the water. She turned her head, groggy, and said, "Who are you?" Jackal was absolutely baffled by the question.

"Me? Who am I? Lady, who the hell are you? I was clearly here first," he said, almost offended at the question.

"Right, you're right. I'm Tyran," Tyran said.

"Tyran? Huh? What the hell are you doing?" Jackal asked.

"Uh, just what you were doing. It looked comfortable, so I wanted to try."

Jackal felt a sharp pain on his hip and quickly looked at it. There was a scar where he had felt the pain in his dream. Immediately, his face went white, and he felt sick as he knew that wasn't there before"

"Sir, are you okay?" Tyran asked.

"Yeah, it's nothing, I think," Jackal said, the memory of his night terror rushing through his head again.

"Sooo, what do you do for a living?" Tyran asked.

"I, uh, I..." Jackal's instincts screamed not to tell her anything, maybe to give her a fake story, but he had a strange feeling about her. That he might never see her again, so why lie? "I'm Jackal, and I, uh, I'm a student at the Frigate Defense School."

"That's so cool!" Tyran exclaimed. "So, are you a frigate? What do you do?"

Jackal laughs and says "could you imagine!"

Tyran looks disappointed and says "you know, you could be if you had a little more confidence"

With a scolding expression on his face Jackal says "oh yeah? You do it then."

"Okay! Can you get me in?" Tyran says.

"Hell No!" Jackal replies

A disappointed look strikes Tyran's face.

"Do you even know how hard it is to get into the Frigate school?" Jackal adds

"Well duh, that's why i asked if you could get me in" Tyran says

"Do you have a life? What are you even doing here? You thought I looked comfortable so you just took a nap in the middle of the day next to a random guy you have never met? What time is it anyways?" Jackal asks.

Jackal checks his watch and his face instantly turns from frustration to fear.

"I'm late!" he shouts and runs for his car.

Jackal sped through traffic and didn't stop. That was one thing he always was good at was driving. As he approached the school he became very anxious, but he always felt this way. Jackal parked his car as close as he could, and ran inside. Luckily everyone at this point was just stretching, but he knew he was still in trouble. Jackal set his FPack in the corner, and turned

around hoping the Professor didn't notice him. As Jack settled into his first stretching position, a foot quickly struck the side of his ribcage knocking him over leaving him gasping for air. Only the professor could kick like that, Jackal thought to himself as he lay on the floor just getting his breath back.

"This is why you will never be a frigate J, nobody here likes you, you're always late, you're weak, and always making a fool of yourself" Professor Zip says aloud for everyone to hear.

Jackal lays on the cold floor, both hand covering where he was kicked, as professor Zip leans down closer to his ear.

"This program was built for people like you, not the frigate school, but this place for people who are wannabe frigates. This little room is home to people who will never be great. You might as well start studying for the paperwork division cause it looks like that is where your ass is gonna land" Professor Zip whispers.

Professor Zip stands up and looks at everyone else. Jackal feels helpless and just lays there for a moment using the beating as an excuse to try to relax for a minute.

"Today is sparring and combat training. Please find a partner" Professor Zip says as he moves to the corner of the room.

"We will start with hand to hand, and then move onto weapons, and then competition time." the professor says sitting in a chair.

These were Jackal's favorite types of days. He got up quickly after realizing he could fight someone, without causing anyone to hate him. He always wanted to fight when he was younger, but was too scared that he would get in trouble and others would hate him. As Jackal stood up, a boy named Tretta came up to Jackal, this was his usual sparring partner. They were usually pretty evenly matched, and Tretta usually barely won their matches because of size advantage.

Tretta asks "How are you feeling today?"

Smirking, Jackal says "Just glad I get to beat someone up"

Tretta smirks back at him "you never win".

"Oh look at me, I'm so big and strong, I'm 6 '6" and 280" Jackals says mockingly, rolling his eyes.

"You all may begin" Professor Zip says.

Jackal immediately throws his first punch at Tretta, but he quickly responds by dodging almost effortlessly and returning with a well executed punch towards the gut. Luckily Jackal is pretty athletic, and is able to jump back just in time before it hits him.

Even though they aren't Frigates, or even technically training to become one, the assistants have some of the best hand to hand combat skills in the world, just below the Frigate. Assistants are the ones who do the paperwork, and often carry Frigate things, in hopes they will one day become a Frigate, but this has only happened once. And he is not a well known Frigate either. Assistants are not technically needed, but make things a lot easier. But also they are usually treated awful. Some of which are even sacrificed at the Frigates' will. But sometimes they end up tougher, because they haven't had everything handed to them. This is what Jackal's mother wants for him. She wants him to work to become a frigate, so he can be successful, and well known. She really just wants what is best for him.

As Jackal slid back a bit, he regained his footing, and tried a new spinning kick he saw, but Tretta caught it, and it knocked Jackal to the ground. Tretta let him get up so they could continue fighting. He liked it just as much as Jackal did. After he regrounded, Tretta took a step back, both of them being a bit more cautious than before. Tretta then quickly jabbed at Jackal, and landed a hard blow to the gut. Jackal was knocked back, and coughing. He threw up, but kept standing. A searing pain on the side of his hip where his tattoo was almost immediately started after the punch. Jackal's face went pale, but he still stood, bearing the pain. Tretta thought his reaction was just from his punch so he continued on. Even though Jackal was in immense pain, he felt loose, and like his whole body was cool. He could feel where he was twitching and it was as if he could control it. As Tretta tried to land a final blow to keep Jackal down, Jackal's mind opened up. It's as if his body was screaming to use it. He could feel everything, the ligaments, tendons, muscle fibers, everything. Jackal did a back handspring backwards to dodge Tretta's blow, but the second his feet touched the ground he was able to transfer his moment straight back into a front handspring using his muscles and body, he whipped himself back into an extremely quick front handspring. When his hands made contact with the ground he dug his fingers into the mats and simultaneously pulled down throwing his legs over his head at immense speeds with his feet coming straight down on to Tretta. Tretta was able to get his arms above his head, but Jackal came down so hard, that gunshot-like sound echoed through the room. Tretta was launched back onto the ground with a loud thud. Tetra was immediately dazed into confusion with a concussion and broken arm. Jackal was also knocked over, but he got up quickly waiting for a return attack from Tretta, but nothing came. Jackal could still feel it all, without thinking he whipped his hand up, and caught Professor Zip's foot which was about to hit him the same spot as before. Zip's leg came in so hard, it pushed Jackal back a foot, but he immediately found his footing, and while still holding onto Professor's leg, he twisted his body and kicked Zip to the ground, Jackal moving his body in an almost supernatural way. Professor Zip was startled at the retaliation, but quickly got up.

"That's new" Zip says grinning

Jackal doesn't say anything, and faces professor Zip head on. The whole class is watching this now, and everyone is intrigued that Jackal took down Tretta so easily, and everyone is stunned about landing a blow on the professor.

"Bring it on J. you think you're strong now. Lets see how it matches against a B level Frigate." Zip says

Jackal with a newfound sense of pride, and confidence he says "Alright but don't let me kill you."

The searing pain in his hip began to fade, but while its fading Jackal rains a fury of punches at professor zip, but they slowly weaken with the pain in his hip. Jackal almost immediately feels exhausted, and the control leaves his body with the pain.

"You can't keep punching forever." Zip says in a teasing tone, as he is uninjured from Jackal's Wrath.

As the pain fades completely from Jackal's hip, he can't even hear the shouting and cheering which is happening behind him. Once the pain fades completely, he fades out of consciousness into blackness.

Chapter 2

As Jackal opened his eyes, his mom was standing over him. She took a deep breath as he opened his eyes, and sat back. Jack realized he was in the hospital, and he had an IV in his arm. His mouth felt dry, and everything was extremely sore.

"Thank god" Jackals mom said.

"Owwwww, what happened?" Jackal groans.

"I don't know, you tell me" She said

"Well I just remember being at school, and I got punched really hard." Jackal says excluding the details of the last half of the fight.

"The doctors said you were out for almost 8 hours. I knew it was a bad idea to send you to this school. I can barely pay my way for you to go there, and this bill isn't gonna help much"

"Mom, I can get a job, you just have to let me. I can help pay for this, and maybe make a career else where"

"No, this is how you are gonna do it. I pay for you too, and you're already there. You are gonna finish, and get a job more successful than mine, and gonna live a comfortable life""

"Dont you think I should get to make a decision like that mom?"

Jackal's mom sits there and looks at him as if he is stupid.

"You know, you could just get a wife, make your money, then retire. That's all you gotta do. I'm here, working my ass off everyday, and no closer to retirement."

"Mom, please let me help you. I don't want to burden you with money anymore, that's all you talk about these days." Jackal looks her in her eyes, he can see she has been getting skinnier from not eating as much and all the stress of trying to put food on the table.

"You know I can't let you do that Jackal. I love you, this is why I am doing this for you."

Jackal sits quietly, contemplating what to do. He feels awful, as his whole life he has relied on his mom. He has never had to pay for school, never had to pay for food, gas, or really anything. But recently prices have been going up. As they sit there in silence, it's as if they are speaking using only their eyes. Jackal got very close to his mom after she divorced his dad and made him leave. She hasn't loved anyone but Jackal since, and her trust is not earned easily. Jackal knows his mom works hard, and he loves her for that, but he has noticed the consequences.

"Mom, I really could help. I am strong, young, and I have a personality that is easy to work with."

"You do? All your professors say otherwise to me. All they see is that you want to leave the academy."

"Yeah? Well I don't want to suck up to somebody for the rest of my life. You know I won't be a frigate, or even close to one. I will be stuck helping some rich fighter for the rest of my life"

She looks Jackal in the eyes with a ferocious look "Listen here. You may not have powers yet, but I know you will. I know you can make it to the top. And if you don't I know you would be a great assistant. If I were a frigate I would definitely have you as my assistant"

"That's because you're my mom!"

The room goes silent again. The next few hours pass, and not another word is spoken to each other till the doctors came back in.

"It looks like your vitals are reading normally now, and you can return to your classes tomorrow. We just recommend being a little more careful this time" the doctor says, as he hands Jackals mom the paper work and the bill.

"If you need to set up a payment plan for the bill you can call the number at the bottom of this page" the doctor says just before stepping out of the room.

Jackal can see his mothers eyes well up with tears as she looks at the bill. He feels a deep pain in his heart. He always feels this way when he sees his mom cry. He knows that the number the doctors told her about was to the same agency that runs all the payment plans. She had their number memorized by this point. And it made him sick to the stomach to think about that. As they got up and left the hospital, Jackal was dropped off at the academy to get his car back and headed home. When he got home, there was a plate for him on the table with his mother nowhere in sight. His mothers food was delicious. He had been to many restaurants, and had lots of good food, but there was just something about his moms food that tasted so comforting to him.

Chapter 3

Jackal was driven by his mom to school the next morning. There was a little small talk, but they stayed mostly silent the whole way there. When Jackal headed inside, everyone looked at him. This was new. He never wanted attention so it made him uncomfortable to be in the hotseat. As he walked into the class room and sat down, people moved to other seats around him. He didn't understand. Even Professor Zip wasn't approaching him like normal.

"Welcome to class today everyone. Today will be a bit more of a slow day as we all know what happened yesterday. Please keep Tretta in your minds, as he should make a full recovery over the next few months"

Jackal's stomach twisted and he immediately became nauseous at hearing this. He stumbled out to the bathroom, and puked in the trash can in there. Jackals couldn't stop thinking. I did what? Is he okay? What should I do? How did I? What the hell happened? He puked again, sick at the image in his head. All he could see was Tretta with a bloody head, and a neck which looked broken. He didn't know if this is what it actually looked like, but what if it did. Did his eyes deceive him at the time? Jackal heard footsteps coming into the bathroom.

Professor zip peeked his head in, while Jackal was puking for the 3rd time into the trashcan at the image in his head. He couldn't even look up to see who it was, nor did he care

"You doing alright?" Zip says

Jackal just looks at him, his eyes bloodshot and tearing from puking so much. What is happening? Why is he being nice? Did I kill him?

"You know Tretta will be okay" Zip says as he sits next to Jackal

"You really roughed him up though. What got into you? Maybe a power from somewhere we don't know about. I don't know if you remember, but at that moment it seemed like you could beat me."

Jackal looked him in the eyes like a dying dog would and said " what did I do to him? The last thing I remember was trying to beat you too. Did I kill him? You could have, and if I was stronger than y..." Jackal began puking again as the sight in his head only got uglier.

"He is not dead, I promise. You did crack his skull, and fracture some of his back bones from the pressure your kick did on top of him, but luckily with today's medicine he will be alright. And hopefully back here soon enough. He probably never will be as strong as he was, but he should be able to make a comeback to the academy." Zip explains putting a hand on Jackal's back.

"I didn't think you had it in you. I didn't really think any of you guys had it in you." He sits next to Jackal, just offering his company at this point.

"I want to help you. The world isn't getting any better out there, and only so many people can rise above the world. The stars above the world don't care about me and you.